

**Wrestling with Silence:
Emily Dickinson's Calvinist God**

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Silence is all we dread.
There's Ransom in a Voice –
But Silence is Infinity.
Himself have not a face. (Fr 1300)¹

The tension between Emily Dickinson's deep anchoring in New England Calvinism—or orthodox Congregationalism, as the denomination came to be called—and her recognition of the inadequacy of the Calvinist heritage to contemporary spiritual experience inspires some of her most intense, ferocious, and distressed verse. Summarizing a half-century of change in Dickinson's religious culture, Jane Donahue Eberwein observes: "In her childhood, belief seemed all but inevitable; by the time she died in 1886, agnosticism and even atheism had become easier positions to justify intellectually" ("Is Immortality" 69). Scientific discoveries, industrialization and the growth of capitalist economy, and, last but not least, the unprecedented bloodshed of the Civil War seriously undermined faith in a benevolent Deity and a divinely ordered universe. Despite the efforts of subsequent generations of revivalists to invest the ossified structures of habit and belief with relevant meaning, the Calvinist paradigm crumbled away under the pressures of cultural change. Congregational ministers and theologians gathered at the National Council in Boston in 1865 were even prepared to compromise their sectarian spirit for the sake of uniting believers against the spread of atheism, which their official report implicitly identified with the Darwinian theory of evolution:

[W]e desire to promote a closer fellowship of all Christian denominations in the faith and work of the gospel, especially against popular and destructive forms of unbelief, which assail the foundations of all religion, both natural and revealed; which know no God but nature; no Depravity but physical malformation, immaturity of powers, or some incident of outward condition; no Providence but the working of material causes and of statistical laws; no Revelation but that of conscious-

ness; no Redemption but the elimination of evil by a natural sequence of suffering; no Regeneration but the natural evolution of a higher type of existence; no Retribution but the necessary consequences of physical and psychological laws. (Walker 557-58)

The documents of the 1865 Council demonstrate not only Congregationalism's response to the intellectual challenge of natural science but also the growing liberalization of Congregationalism itself, visible in the amendment proposed by a Rev. Leavitt from New York City—but rejected by the majority of delegates with Edwards Amasa Park of Andover Theological Seminary at their lead—that the Council's Declaration of Faith does not define the doctrine as Calvinistic so as to avoid alienating believers (Walker 560). Like Andover in Park's time, Amherst was a stronghold of New England Congregational orthodoxy, inculcated both in church and in educational institutions. Amherst Academy, Amherst College, and Mount Holyoke Female Seminary at nearby South Hadley were closely allied with the Congregational church and designed to provide both academic and religious education. The appointment of Julius H. Seeyle, President of Amherst College, to the national committee which prepared the updated creed of 1883 (Walker 579) attests to Amherst's standing as a major center of latter-day Congregationalism. Still, despite its theological and social conservatism the poet's home town did not escape secularization as in the late nineteenth century institutional religion became a social ritual increasingly separated from other spheres of life. Whereas *The Articles of Faith and Government* adopted by Amherst's First Congregational Church in the 1850s stated that "immoral conduct, breach of express covenant vows, neglect of acknowledged religious or relative duties, and avowed disbelief in our articles of Faith" were "offenses subject to the censure of the Church," three decades later the fact that Emily Dickinson's brother Austin had a lasting extramarital relationship with Mabel Loomis Todd, wife of an astronomy professor at Amherst College and twenty-seven years his junior, did not interfere with his position as a prominent member of the First Church or prevent him from being asked, in recognition of his service to the parish and town, to contribute an essay to the volume celebrating the Church's 150th anniversary in 1889.

In the mid-nineteenth century, Amherst and all of western Massachusetts were swept by several waves of the protracted Second Great Awakening. In her teens and twenties Emily Dickinson witnessed four major religious revivals: one at Mount Holyoke Seminary in 1848 and three at Amherst's First Church in 1844-1845, 1850, and 1858 (Siegfried 63). Although she saw her classmates as well as her father, sister, brother, and future sister-in-law join the church, Dickinson remained distrustful of revivalistic fervor and rhetoric and never made a formal profession of faith.

Her resistance to conversion at Mount Holyoke resulted in a tormented sense of failure (L 23, 1848), yet over the next decade the poet seems to have accepted her unconverted state. During the great revival of 1850 she half-skeptically wrote to a friend: "Christ is calling everyone here, all my companions have answered, even my darling Vinnie [Emily's sister Lavinia] believes she loves, and trusts him, and I am standing alone in rebellion, and growing very careless" (L 35). Some letters from that period contain anxious references to religion (L 36, L 39, 1850), but Dickinson's bemused and ironic comments on the revival of 1858 are already those of a distanced observer (L 194). Soon afterwards she wholly refused to attend Sabbath services, withdrawing into the tumultuous privacy of her belief just as she withdrew into the privacy of the Dickinson mansion. Indeed, Calvinism functions in her oeuvre in a manner somewhat analogous to her family home: it is a space into which she was born and in which she has remained; a space that provides her with language, imagery, and a frame for experience; a space of frequent longing, conflict, and emotional hunger. It is also a space governed by a stern Godhead sometimes indistinguishable from the poet's father, Edward Dickinson; and yet, last but not least, a space within which she has negotiated a realm of freedom and independence.

Some scholars have made a case for Dickinson's agnosticism or atheism. David Porter puts forth the strong but one-sided claim that she is a poet of utter negativity whose "desolation as an artist lies at the terrifying depth of thought ... where the final No is reached" (170). In a recent study Nina Baym convincingly demonstrates how Dickinson deployed scientific discourse "to unsettle [Amherst] religion" and quotes a series of "scientifically anti-theological" poems which argue the impossibility of knowledge about an afterlife (148-49). However, Dickinson could also conceive of belief as unproblematic, childlike in its simplicity, as in "I never saw a Moor" (Fr 800) or "Some keep the Sabbath going to Church" (Fr 236), and while such unreservedly optimistic statements are rare and tend to belong to the earlier period, they reflect the diversity and fluidity of her religious attitudes. Whereas Dickinson relentlessly examines and dismantles her Calvinist legacy, she hardly ever addresses the question of God's existence but even in moments of disbelief is ready to stipulate that God is. She presents uncertainty as a prerequisite of faith, conceding that certainty, were it possible, would make faith redundant (Fr 978). She also acknowledges that however disturbing the uncertainty can become, to abandon faith is even more difficult than to uphold it: "The abdication of Belief / Makes the Behavior small—/ Better an ignis fatuus / Than no illume at all—" (Fr 1581).

The growing inaccessibility of religious experience within the Calvin-

istic framework and the consequent spiritual alienation of the individual is dramatized in Dickinson's poetry through the images of a dead or mutilated God: "a lifeless Deity" (Fr 795), "the Funeral of God" (Fr 1112), or, perhaps most memorably, a God whose "Right Hand ... is amputated now" (Fr 1581) (Eberwein, "Is Immortality" 67). Given the desacralization of everyday life, the argument from design endorsed by the seventeenth-century Puritans or, in Dickinson's time, by the President of Amherst College, geologist and former minister Edward Hitchcock, no longer sufficed as proof of the workings of Divine Providence. In his works, notably *Religion of Geology* and *Religious Lectures on Peculiar Phenomena in the Four Seasons*, Hitchcock combined science, natural observation, and theology to argue that the organization of nature provides solid evidence of the existence of God and that all natural processes are emblems of spiritual reality.² Dickinson explodes this argument in poems which unmask the impossibility of discerning any divine order in nature: "Four Trees—upon a solitary Acre— / Without Design / Or Order, or Apparent Action— / Maintain—" (Fr 778); "From Cocoon forth a Butterfly / As Lady from her Door / Emerged ... Without Design—that I could trace" (Fr 610). However elaborate intellectually, the project of natural theology fails the test of empirical observation and thus cannot nourish wavering belief.

In an increasingly secular culture meaningful religious experience had to be personalized, invested with emotion and based on an intimate relationship with God. This movement, which Richard Rabinowitz terms the "quest for feeling" (220), underlies both the Victorian sentimentalization of religion with its shift of focus to the human and therefore more accessible Jesus and the mid- and late-nineteenth-century development of spiritualism, which answered the need for direct communication with transcendence. Dickinson's project to explore the very possibility of a personal relation to the Calvinist Godhead (Buell 129) can be perceived as a version of this quest translated into Calvinist terms. Dickinson's religious poetry is informed by an impassioned effort to establish an intimate, unmediated, and, most importantly, reciprocal relationship with the heavenly Father, a relationship which will affirm her own dignity just as it does his. However, the Calvinist image of a Jehovah hidden on high, absent from human affairs, and unmoved in his sovereignty—an image the poet can neither accept nor abandon—precludes such intimacy. Hence the ferocity of much of her religious verse, whose sarcasm and resentment are pointed not only at the Calvinist system of belief but also at the Deity himself. More than anything else, it is this proud demand for equality with the Maker that fuels Dickinson's spiritual combat.

Such equality, intimacy, and reciprocity of the human-divine relationship are epitomized in Dickinson's rewriting of the Genesis narrative of

Jacob's encounter with the Angel. In the biblical story God assumes human form to wrestle with Jacob, who prevails and obtains a blessing, having seen the Lord face-to-face without being destroyed (Gen. 32. 24-30). Cynthia Griffin Wolff notes that the Jacob episode was of central importance to Amherst Congregationalists as an example of the individual's persistent struggle for belief and the "archetypal model for New England Protestant conversions" (144, 146). Its appeal to the poet, however, seems to lie neither in the struggle for faith nor in God's propensity to inflict pain, as Wolff suggests, but, first and foremost, in the annulled distance between the human and divine adversaries and their prolonged, one-to-one combat which requires undivided attention from both parties.

A little East of Jordan,
Evangelists record,
A Gymnast and an Angel
Did wrestle long and hard—

Till morning touching mountain—
And Jacob, waxing strong,
The Angel begged permission
To Breakfast—to return!

Not so, said cunning Jacob!
"I will not let thee go
Except thou bless me"—Stranger!
The which acceded to—

Light swung the silver fleeces
"Peniel" Hills beyond,
And the bewildered Gymnast
Found he had worsted God! (Fr 145 B)

Significantly, Dickinson's account of the biblical event omits God's wounding of Jacob, which would impair the poem's optimism and its unproblematic economy of gain. Instead, in analogy to the intimacy of the wrestlers' physical contact, "morning touch[es] mountain," providing a magnificent display of natural glory to accompany Jacob's triumph over his antagonist. The tone, playful and festive rather than ominous or ironic, corresponds to Dickinson's view of this encounter as an exercise in metaphysical gymnastics, whose strain is reflected in the poem's contorted syntax. With divine violence removed from the narrative, the relation between the human individual and God is for once symmetrical, as underscored by alliteration (*Gymnast-God; morning-mountain*). The poem celebrates human dignity and strength, while the God who lets himself be defeated reveals another dimension of his divinity rather than suffer a loss

in power. Richard Ellis stresses Jacob's recognition "that the hierarchical/intimate relationship with God is multidimensional. It includes both the experience of mastering God, a bewildering awareness as the accession to one's full powers always is, and the experience of being blessed by God" (46). Notably, the poem erases the Angel's renaming of Jacob as Israel, which precedes the blessing in the Genesis episode. In this way the power to name is implicitly reserved for Jacob, since it is he who in the biblical narrative calls the place "Peniel," i.e., "face of God." The final moment of heightened consciousness as Jacob recognizes his adversary renders him a poet figure and thus Dickinson's counterpart, suggesting that the combat is also a test of poetic power, a struggle for inspiration and control over language.

Envisioned as wrestling, the paradigmatic relationship with the God-head is thus for Dickinson a potentially violent yet fair confrontation in which God recognizes the human being as an adversary and partner. By staging the combat within the realm of poetry, Dickinson gains a paradoxical ascendancy over the Maker insofar as he becomes a character in her poems, "worsted" by being circumscribed by a particular representation. This may explain the reversal of the Jacob episode in two letters written in 1886, shortly before the poet's death (L 1035, L 1042), where it is Jacob who gives the blessing: "Audacity of Bliss, said Jacob to the Angel 'I will not let thee go except I bless thee'—Pugilist and Poet, Jacob was correct—" (L 1042). It is noteworthy that although Dickinson does depart from Congregational orthodoxy in other respects, most strikingly in her rejection of the doctrines of innate depravity and predestination (Eberwein, "Graphicer" 176-77; Jones), she exploits this poetic ascendancy over God without departing from the Calvinist concept of Jehovah, which functions in her poetry as a negative but ubiquitous reference.

The elementary principles of Calvinism were expressed in the *Westminster Assembly's Shorter Catechism*, a series of a hundred and seven questions and answers formulated in 1648 and still used for children's religious instruction two centuries later. The *Catechism* began by defining the purpose of human life: "Man's chief end is to glorify God and to enjoy him forever" (3), and proceeded to define God, in question four, as "a Spirit, infinite, eternal, and unchangeable, in his being, wisdom, power, holiness, justice, goodness, and truth" (5). These two quotations alone bring into sharp relief the unbridgeable distance between the human being and the abstract Deity, whose catalogued attributes, as Perry Miller explained in his classic study, make him "all the more difficult to imagine pictorially, since He is now envisaged as constantly active in a number of thoroughly contradictory directions" (*New England Mind* 12).³ Dickinson captures this paradox and its disconcerting effect on the believer in the chilling apostro-

phe "Awful Father of Love" (Fr 1200), where God's eagerness to chastise humans all but nullifies his mercy. Another popular source of Calvinist creed was the Isaac Watts hymnal, whose influence on Dickinson's prosody and imagery has been discussed at length (England; Wolosky; Cooley). Watts's hymns multiplied images of a remote, formidable Jehovah, as in the following: "Oh! the almighty Lord, / How matchless is thy power! / Tremble, O earth, beneath his word,— / While all the heavens adore" (2:80).

Dickinson defies the Calvinist image of God in poems framed as sentimental complaint (Fr 195B, Fr 1032), ironic restatement of biblical truths (Fr 1752), or overt blasphemy (Fr 1332, Fr 1500), poems protesting against Jehovah's possessiveness and jealousy, greed and indifference, cruelty and readiness to inflict suffering and death, and, perhaps most fiercely, his sovereign detachment and disrespect for human dignity.

'Heavenly Father'—take to thee
 The supreme iniquity
 Fashioned by thy candid Hand
 In a moment contraband—
 Though to trust us—seem to us
 More respectful—'We are Dust'—
 We apologize to thee
 For thine own Duplicity—(Fr 1500)

The angry sarcasm of this poem is underscored by neighboring rhymes and trochaic meter, which along with the uniform length of lines—seven syllables—create a sing-song rhythm reminiscent of children's poetry. This recognizable rhythmic model and the opening apostrophe, characteristic of prayers, sharply contrast with the accusatory tone of the poem which questions both God's fatherly nature and the Calvinist view of human worthlessness. The biblical phrase "dust thou art, and unto dust shalt thou return," which Dickinson paraphrases, is uttered by Jehovah as he expels the first parents from Eden, sentencing the human race to toil, pain, and death (Gen. 3.19). But if people, made in God's likeness, represent "the supreme iniquity," then, according to the poet's rigorous logic, the same trait must be attributed to the Creator. Dickinson does not focus on the Fall as original sin but on the subsequent expulsion from Paradise, which she blasphemously construes as the original wrong done to humankind by a God who first offered people happiness, then distrustfully put them to test, and finally doomed them to suffering. Undermining the dogma of God's benevolence, Dickinson contemplates the terrifying possibility that the metaphysical order is different from Calvinist teaching and that the human individual is left wholly to him/herself, unable to rely on

the hostile Deity against the chaos of the universe.

Although, judging by the number of references in the poems and letters, Dickinson's favorite book of the Bible was Matthew (Capps 192-93), relatively few of her poems deal with the person of Christ. S.P. Rosenbaum's *Concordance* lists 137 references to the word God, 26 to Lord, about 25 to Father in the sense of God (the exact reference cannot always be determined because of Dickinson's tendency to conflate the Maker with the earthly father figure), and 7 to Jehovah, as compared with 22 references to Jesus, 12 to Christ, and 10 to Savior. The poet focuses most of her attention on the relationship with the Calvinist Godhead rather than construe intimate friendship with the human Jesus as a remedy for spiritual longing. The sharp division between the two persons of the Trinity, who in Dickinson's poetry have radically different attributes, derives not only from Victorian sentimental Christianity (St. Armand 141-46), but also from Calvinist piety itself. Watts's hymns overtly instructed believers in the contrasting emotional responses they owe the Father and the Son:

How strong thine arm is, mighty God
Who would not fear thy name?
Jesus, how sweet thy graces are!
Who would not love the Lamb? (1:49)

Such polarization between Jehovah's sovereignty and Christ's meekness, and emphasis on the one to the detriment of the other, underwent a simple reversal in the sentimental shift of focus from the Father to the Son. This shift is reflected in Harriet Beecher Stowe's *The Minister's Wooing* (1859), where Mrs. Marvyn, mourning the supposed death of her unconverted son, is saved from madness by the black servant Candace, who preaches the feminine gospel of the Savior's boundless love which overpowers the Father's stern justice (736-37). While Dickinson embraces the sentimental doctrine of Christ's brotherly love, she is drawn to Christ not as a merciful Savior but as a fellow sufferer who also experienced the Father's silence and duplicity. In "God is a distant—stately Lover—" (Fr 615) Jehovah uses Christ to win human love and then claims it for himself. In another poem Jesus is sent to check the tenacity of faith by walking the plank (Fr 1459). Christ's last words on the cross, "la'-ma sa-bach'-thani?" ("Why hast thou forsaken me?") (Matt. 27.46) are recalled as "that scalding" prayer (Fr 283). In contrast to both orthodox Congregationalists and sentimental Christians, Dickinson virtually ignores the redemptive aspect of the Crucifixion, envisaging it instead as the most widely publicized instance of human anguish: "One Crucifixion is recorded—only— ... Our Lord—indeed—made Compound Witness— / And yet— / There's newer—nearer Crucifixion / Than That—" (Fr 670). Whereas in a letter to

Thomas Wentworth Higginson she declared that "To be human is more than to be divine, for when Christ was divine, he was discontented till he had been human" (L 519), in the poems Dickinson contends that Jesus's human condition belittles his divinity and power. Christ is represented as capable of compassion but powerless to ease anguish (Fr 197, 377). The variants for an 1862 poem, "Savior! I've no one else to tell—" (Fr 295A) and "Father—I bring thee—not myself—" (Fr 295B) reveal the poet's hesitation in choosing between the sympathetic but helpless Jesus and the mighty but indifferent Godhead as addressees of that poignant prayer.

In New England Calvinism the emphasis on an Old Testament God was amplified by the millennialist vision of New Englanders as the latter-day Israel who, in John Winthrop's sermon on board the *Arbella* in 1630, entered a federal covenant with God under which they had special obligations but also special privileges. By the early nineteenth century the nation's legal contract with the Creator had collapsed and the Congregational Church suffered disestablishment in successive New England states: Connecticut in 1818, New Hampshire in 1819, and Massachusetts in 1833 (Rabinowitz 141). Still, the evangelicals retained a vigorous belief in their millennial mission, manifested, e.g., in Lyman Beecher's scheme of universal moral improvement (Rabinowitz 138-51) or in his daughter Harriet's vision of an ideal society, founded on a marriage of nostalgia and prophecy.⁴ The millennial project also informed the educational priorities of Mount Holyoke Seminary, dedicated to fostering conversions and developing spiritual discipline as a way of preparing students for their future missionary work at home and abroad. (Baym speculates that it may have been Mary Lyon's focus on training missionaries and the allure of exotic places which initially attracted young Dickinson to that school [225].) Independently of the federal covenant, which concerned a community or nation, personal religious experience was structured by the covenant of grace, that is, the individual's contract with God sealed at the moment of conversion. The believer accepted the obligation to abide by God's laws in order to earn benefits and avoid chastisement. In Miller's words, "Grace is a covenant, and the essence of a covenant, [Puritan] theologians never wearied of explaining, is an agreement between two agents, both of whom must know the conditions" ("Preparation" 260). In the mid-nineteenth century Congregational ministers no longer described the Godhead as wrathful or vindictive but offered believers ample scope for trust, joy, and confidence, inviting the celebration of grace and glory and stressing the importance of Christ's mercy in the work of salvation (Eberwein, "Graphicer"). Writing in 1889, the Rev. Aaron M. Colton, who had been pastor of Amherst's First Church from 1840 to 1852, refuted as "fictitious and false" the allegation that the Congregationalism of ear-

lier days made the believers "sour, gloomy, unhappy" (67) and testified that he had never heard any of the outstanding New England preachers speak of imminent punishment, damnation of the nonelect, or the horrors of hell (68-70). But whereas the conditions of the covenant became more relaxed, the individual's relation to God continued to be framed in transactional terms. Not only did the *Shorter Catechism* phrase matters theological in economic language, but the same kind of discourse was also deployed in contemporary sermons. For example, Charles Wadsworth, a Presbyterian minister and the most likely prototype of the lover figure in Dickinson's poems and letters (Lease), spoke of "God's providential and gracious economies," "the Divine economy" ("Christian Influence" 7, 18) and "the economy of grace" ("Grace and Works" 13). The Congregational creed adopted as late as 1883 contained such legalistic formulations as "the providence of God, by which he executes his eternal purposes in the government of the world" or "our first parents by disobedience fell under the righteous condemnation of God" (Walker 580).

In the Dickinson family such discourse seems to have prevailed even in one's personal communication with the Deity. On 1 May 1873, in the wake of yet another revival at Amherst's First Congregational Church, Edward Dickinson penned a note saying, "I hereby give myself to God," which he signed and dated (Leyda 2: 200). In a poem written about a decade earlier Emily Dickinson represents personal contract with God in similar terms:

I gave Myself to Him—
And took Himself, for Pay—
The solemn contract of a Life
Was ratified, this way—

The Wealth might disappoint—
Myself a poorer prove
Than this great Purchaser suspect,
The Daily Own—of Love

Depreciate the Vision—
But till the Merchant buy—
Still Fable—in the Isles of spice—
The subtle Cargoes—lie—

At least—'tis Mutual—Risk—
Some—found it—Mutual Gain—
Sweet Debt of Life—Each Night to owe—
Insolvent—every Noon— (Fr 426)

This is one of several poems in which Dickinson uses a persona to re-

hearse the experience of conversion, and just as the poems of mystic marriage, which also belong to that group, this poem conflates Jesus with the lover. The *Shorter Catechism* defined conversion as "a work of God's Spirit, whereby convincing us of our sin and misery, enlightening our minds in the knowledge of Christ, and renewing our wills, he doth persuade and enable us to embrace Jesus Christ freely offered to us in the gospel" (20). Thus, paradoxically, conversion involved a taking which was volitional *because* ordained by God. As Wadsworth phrased it, "God makes us willing, and that very willingness is our free choice" ("Grace and Works" 9). In her characteristic insistence on the equality of the human and divine parties, Dickinson reverses this economy of grace by having the speaker initiate the exchange: "I gave ... and took." The capitalized pronouns "Myself" and "Him" in the opening line highlight the symmetry of the transaction, by virtue of which each participant may receive less than expected.⁵ The economic character of the human-divine relationship is stressed by the epithet "great Purchaser," which echoes the *Shorter Catechism's* "redemption purchased by Christ" (19). As Dickinson plays the catechismal meaning of purchase, obtain by sacrifice, against its commercial meaning, obtain by payment, the Redeemer becomes a Merchant who buys a life. The poem's progress is from the gravely legalistic to the sensuous and lyrical, culminating in the image of "Isles of spice"—an exotic, lavish nowhere, like the Brazil, Peru, or India of other poems (Fr 687, Fr 418C). The subtly sexual imagery of the final two stanzas, emphasized by the flowing rhythm of the short meter (6-6-8-6) and the exact or consonant rhymes, complicates the poem's economy with its premise that the human soul and divine grace are commodities. Indeed, by the end of the poem the emotionless framework of a business transaction collapses, the speaker willingly seduced into the sentimental bond of the unpayable "Sweet Debt of Life."

The economy of Dickinson's Christ poems as opposed to her Jehovah poems again points to the polarization between the Father and the Son. The contract with Jesus involves a paradoxical gain; the relationship with the Maker is envisioned as deprivation or loss: "Burglar! Banker—Father! / I am poor once more!" (Fr 39); "I asked no other thing— / No other— was denied—" (Fr 687); "Was God so economical? / His Table's spread too high for Us— ... God keep His Oath to Sparrows— / Who of little Love— know how to starve—" (Fr 195B). The Godhead is represented as a dubious business partner, likely to break his covenantal promises and therefore necessarily approached with caution. In an 1859 letter Dickinson wrote, "God was penurious with me, which makes me shrewd with Him" (L 207). Even though the situation which occasioned this wary remark was trivial enough—that night her younger sister Vinnie had a headache which prevented her from doing the usual duties—to the poet such a breach in

the evening routine suggested the vulnerability of her world, from which anyone she loved could be taken away by God's whim. A poem dated to about the same year, "I had some things that I called mine—/ And God, that he called his—," toys with the idea of securing by law an inviolable territory of one's own as the persona threatens to sue God for encroaching upon her property:

I'll institute an "Action"—
 I'll vindicate the law—
 Jove! Choose your counsel—
 I retain "Shaw"! (Fr 101)

R.W. Franklin's variorum identifies "Shaw," after the 1945 edition by Mabel Loomis Todd and Millicent Todd Bingham, as "a man who used to dig for her—a day laborer" (*Poems*, 1: 139). However, rather than protest against losing a gardener to God, the speaker seems to be invoking *against* God the authority and power of Lemuel Shaw, Chief Justice of Massachusetts from 1830 to 1860, who was still in office when Dickinson composed the poem about 1859. As the daughter of a leading Amherst lawyer, she must have been familiar with the name of this influential jurist. Accordingly, the speaker not only threatens to bring God, the heavenly Judge, to court, but secures her triumph in the prospective trial by reserving the services of an eminent earthly judge to defend her autonomy. She thus questions God's sovereignty not only by advising him to "choose [his] counsel," but also by pitting divine sovereignty against that of Shaw. The poem's argument, however, is complicated by the use of quotation marks around "Action" and "Shaw," Dickinson's frequent means of undermining the authority of official discourse. In an ironic reversal, the carefully staged lawsuit proves futile because in actuality the framework of Massachusetts law is utterly incompatible with that of divine law. By treating the legalistic language of Congregationalism literally Dickinson exposes its fallacy but as a result subverts the poem's case against Jehovah.

A paradoxical prayer poem dated to about 1878 reiterates this demand for God's recognition of human autonomy, again structuring the human-divine relationship in economic terms:

My Maker—let me be
 A World or two from thee—
 But nearer this
 I more should miss— (Fr 1463A)

Whether the speaker measures loss against profit, "I more should miss [than gain]," or loss against loss, "I more should miss [than I miss now]," she pleads for the freedom to regulate this economy by regulating the dis-

tance from God. Shunning closer contact with Jehovah may suggest his covetousness, his claiming all while giving little, or, more ominously, his propensity to harm. The phrase "A World or two from thee—" situates the relationship in a cosmic perspective, envisaging the Deity as a formidable Creator of heavenly bodies, but in the variants for this line the poet tested other possibilities, construing the Maker as an all-demanding lover ("Enamored most of thee—") or a next-door neighbor ("A Fence or two from thee—"). The latter image, reminiscent of "Our Old Neighbor—God" from an earlier poem (Fr 689), brings the Godhead within the local or domestic realm yet by doing so implies not so much his friendly proximity as his neighborly habit of prying on people, his constant scrutiny of human souls. God's omniscience was strongly emphasized in the religious instruction of children with a view to developing their conscience and promoting the habit of self-scrutiny. The poet's niece cites Austin Dickinson's childhood idea of God's surveillance: "My father said when he was a little boy he supposed God sat up over the wood-box in their kitchen. ... he explained that he had to keep it filled, and so it was the best place for observing whether he did it or not" (Bianchi 28). In a similar vein, nineteen-year-old Emily Dickinson states ironically in a letter to a school friend that although all the family are gone, she is not alone, since "God is sitting here, looking into my very soul to see if I think right tho'ts" (L 31). However light-heartedly, the letter envisions God's omnipresence and omniscience as an oppressive violation of human privacy. Dickinson's niece also reports that in her late years the poet was enthusiastic about the evening prayer composed by her youngest nephew Gib, "O Lord, you take care of me some tonight, and I'll take care of myself some" (Bianchi 65). This anecdote further attests to Dickinson's lasting demand for a relationship with the Deity that would respect her autonomy and self-sufficiency, a demand discordant with the Calvinist emphasis on the individual's humble reliance upon the Almighty for guidance and strength.

As latter-day Congregationalism shifted its focus from the sinfulness of human nature abhorred by a perfect Maker to the possibility of redemption of sins, the contrast between God's absolute knowledge of the human being and the human being's inability to know God and his secret will became the most forcefully articulated asymmetry of the human-divine relationship. Orthodox evangelicals envisaged the Godhead as hidden, incomprehensible, and unapproachable in his transcendent sovereignty. A Watts hymn glorifies the impenetrable mystery of the divine plan:

Lord, we adore thy vast designs,
Th' obscure abyss of Providence!

.....

Now thou array'st thine awful face

In angry frowns, without a smile:
 We, through the cloud, believe thy grace,
 Secure of thy compassion still. (2:109)

Dickinson, for her part, construes the unfathomability of God's plan as a source of anguish, resonating in such poems as "Through the Straight Pass of Suffering" (Fr 187), "Victory comes late—" (Fr 195), or "I should have been too glad, I see—" (Fr 283). She rejects as preposterous Calvinism's requirement to worship an obscure, unresponsive Deity whose very abstractness makes a personal relationship impossible (L 261). The hymn's lesson of trust in Jehovah's benevolence "through the cloud" is subverted in poems which echo and repudiate Watts's rhetoric of reverence and humility. Speaking of "My Business—with the Cloud," Dickinson presents this business as failed, an abortive attempt to find comfort in the inaccessible God who, rather than mercifully heal the speaker's anguish, may himself be prostrate, "subject to Despair" (Fr 292). In another poem dated to the same year 1862, she envisions the hidden, silent God of Calvinism as a cruel experimenter with humanity who refuses to reach out to people with his saving grace but leaves them to grope for faith, testing the limits of their belief and endurance.

I know that He exists.
 Somewhere—in silence—
 He has hid his rare life
 From our gross eyes.

'Tis an instant's play—
 'Tis a fond Ambush—
 Just to make Bliss
 Earn her own surprise!

But—should the play
 Prove piercing earnest—
 Should the glee—glaze—
 In Death's—stiff—stare—

Would not the fun
 Look too expensive!
 Would not the jest—
 Have crawled too far! (Fr 365)

The opening statement "I know that He exists," reinforced by the final period, alludes to the official discourse of Calvinist teaching, whose deficiency is exposed in the lines that follow. The inculcated knowledge of God's existence is empty and unavailing without religious experience, which, as this poem argues, is unattainable within the framework of Calvinism

with its doctrine of the Deity's absolute transcendence, which Dickinson translates into a self-contained indifference and contempt for the allegedly unworthy mortals. The poem's harsh alliteration and the stumbling rhythm of the "gross" Anglo-Saxon monosyllables, especially in the spondaic phrases (*rare life, gross eyes, glee – glaze, stiff – stare*), suggest faltering faith, while the obstinate repetition of gl- and st- clusters in lines 15 and 16 virtually turns the words into empty signifiers, reflecting the void confronted by the persona. The speaker blasphemously accuses the silent God of malevolence, of demanding growth in faith without ever feeding it, and of causing spiritual anguish which may not cease even at death.

As Calvinism vested supreme theological authority in the Bible and emphasized individual experience of the Scriptures, it elevated the Word revealed as the foundation of the believer's spiritual growth, citing Paul's exhortation in Romans, "[f]aith cometh by hearing, and hearing by the word of God" (10.17). In the Dickinson household there were as many as nineteen Bibles (Lease 45). In a letter to Joseph Lyman the poet admired the Bible for "how infinitely wise & how merry it is" and for "the surpassing splendor & force of its speech" and marveled at "the fathomless gulfs of meaning" of Christ's promises of eternal life (Sewall, *Lyman Letters* 73). However, Dickinson seems to have perceived the Scriptures, especially the Old Testament, as a literary account of a one-time revelation, a story of God's dealings with the people of the distant past rather than the living word of God addressed to each and every individual, including herself. In a late poem sent to her adolescent nephew Ned she dramatizes the impossibility of immediate experience of that ancient text: "The Bible is an antique Volume— / Written by faded Men / At the suggestion of Holy Spectres— ... Had but the Tale a warbling Teller— / All the Boys would come— / Orpheu's Sermon captivated— / It did not condemn—" (Fr 1577). Jehovah's scriptural word, often fraught with anger and chastisement, does not reach out to contemporary believers or compensate for his ambiguous silence.

In Emmanuel Levinas's memorable phrase, "silence is not a simple absence of speech; speech lies in the depths of silence like a laughter perfidiously held back" (91). Dickinson, albeit writing in a different historical and intellectual context, seems to conceive of silence in a similar way, as a perfidious withholding of a plethora of meaning by a formidable God. The poem used as the epigraph for this essay construes silence not only as a dreadful non-event in the human world but also as a synonym of Jehovah: identified with infinity, consistently capitalized, and personified as masculine, silence represents the inaccessible Absolute unmediated through language and untranslatable into human terms, as terrifying as the ambiguous whiteness of Melville's whale. Significantly, all three lines refer-

ring to silence end in periods, ominous signs of a finality which precludes any response or engagement. By contrast, in the line "There's Ransom in a Voice—" the dash reflects the liberating open-endedness and potentiality created by speech. Calvinist theology described the elect as "Rescued," "Redeemed," or "Ransomed." By invoking the language of divine election Dickinson invests voice with redemptive power, obliquely engaging the contrast between the brotherly Christ, who in the Gospels speaks face-to-face with his chosen disciples, and the awesome Old Testament Jehovah, absolutely transcendent and silently executing his unfathomable plan.

Orthodox evangelical preachers constantly reminded believers that divine economies are beyond human wisdom. In Wadsworth's words, "God's thoughts are not our thoughts, neither are God's ways our ways" ("Christian Influence" 7). Wadsworth called for trust in the unpredictable time, form, and manner of God's answer to prayers and for humble acceptance of the trials to which God puts human individuals in order to sanctify them. To Emily Dickinson such attempts at mediating the inexplicability of God's ways were painfully and annoyingly inadequate. The speakers of her poems do not accuse the Godhead of absence from human affairs but of gratuitous cruelty and persistent refusal to communicate, which invalidates prayer and frustrates belief (Fr 292, 581, 1200; Fr 283, 373, 1587). Nonetheless, Dickinson clung to the Calvinist categories of thought despite her acute sense of their inadequacy, and while she resisted conversion as the ultimate settlement of one's business with God and rejected the formality of institutional religion and public rituals, she pursued her controversy with the Calvinist Jehovah whose image she detested but could not renounce. As a woman poet privileged by her family's social and financial status but disenfranchised by the patriarchal systems of society and religion, it was in the private realm of poetry that Dickinson could freely stage her combat with God, envisaged variously as the wrestling of equals or a confrontation of human vulnerability with God's indifferent omnipotence (Fr 151, 581). Dickinson's religious poetry projects an alternative to the human-divine asymmetry endorsed by Calvinist teaching and tests different ways of positioning the human being in relation to God. As such, it is both a re-examination of the tenets of Calvinism and a dynamic account of a quest for religious experience structured by the Calvinist heritage.

Notes:

¹ Dickinson's poems are quoted from R. W. Franklin's edition and referred to as Fr and poem number. References to the letters are marked as L followed by letter number and, if relevant, by date. An early version of this article was presented at the New England American Stud-

ies Association Conference in Hartford, Connecticut, April 25-27, 2003. I am grateful to the conference audience and to Jay Fliegelman, Agnieszka Salska, and Barton St. Armand for their helpful comments and suggestions. I also thank Jane Eberwein for generously sharing with me the prepublished manuscript of her essay "'Is Immortality True?'" I gratefully acknowledge the support of the Emily Dickinson International Society, whose Fraser Fallon Scholar in Residence award allowed me to conduct research in Amherst institutions in the fall of 2004.

² There is no evidence that Dickinson heard or read those lectures, first delivered at Amherst College between 1845 and 1849. However, students taking science classes at Amherst Academy, the school she went to from 1840 to 1847, could attend some scientific lectures at the College free of charge (Catalogue 11). Richard B. Sewall argues that given Edward Hitchcock's position as Amherst's leading educator and his energetic support of Mary Lyon and her Mount Holyoke Seminary, where he occasionally lectured, young Dickinson was almost certainly exposed to his typological view of the seasons (Life 343-48). Carlton Lowenberg lists Hitchcock's *Elementary Geology and A Catalogue of Plants Growing Without Cultivation in the Vicinity of Amherst College* among the poet's textbooks (57-59).

³ Perry Miller's vast scholarship on Puritanism and New England thought has been the target of fierce criticism by American Studies/Religious Studies scholars, but while his grand narrative of American intellectual history may be reductive and mythopoeic, his analyses of Calvinist theology have lasting value and as such are cited here.

⁴ Arguably, it is because the sense of federal covenant still prevailed in the revolutionary era that Harriet Beecher Stowe chose to set her New England novels in that period. Hence her descriptions of New England as Hebrew, grounded in the typological relation of "old" to "new" Israel but also in the peculiarly Old Testament character of the region's culture. In *Oldtown Folks* (1869) ante-railroad New England is termed "a sort of half Hebrew theocracy" (885); in *The Pearl of Orr's Island* (1862), where the characters bear Old Testament names and speak in biblical verses, Stowe asserts that "New England, in her earlier days, founding her institutions on the Hebrew Scripture, bred better Jews than Moses could, because she read Moses with the amendments of Christ" (122). The vestigial sense of Puritan errand that Stowe's novels express is absent from Dickinson, but the poet's controversy with Jehovah takes place in the same, predominantly Old Testament spiritual landscape. For comparisons of Stowe's and Dickinson's treatment of Calvinism and sentimental Christianity see Lawrence Buell; Karl Keller 97-124; Barton Levi St. Armand 79-115.

⁵ Dickinson's insistence on human-divine equality is also manifested in "Tie the strings to my Life, My Lord" (Fr 338), another conversion poem from approximately the same year 1862. Although the speaker prays for God's agency, the alliteration of the capitalized words "Life" and "Lord" indicates their equivalence, and the speaker stresses her own decision as primary: "Held fast in Everlasting Race— / By my own Choice, and Thee—."

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